

**Bundesminister**  
**Dr. Johann Wadephul**

**Rede vor der Generalversammlung  
der Vereinten Nationen**

***16 Minuten***

**27.09.2025**

**Madame President,**

It is a pleasure to see you.

And a pleasure to see you in this role.

**(Pause)**

**Excellencies,**

**On December 10th, 1932,** a friend picked up **Albert Einstein** and his wife at their **house near Berlin.**

Together, they **travelled to the German port city of Bremen.**

Albert and Elsa Einstein **boarded a ship to North America.**

He planned to **accept a three-month position as visiting professor** at the California Institute of Technology.

**Albert Einstein – one of the greatest physicists of all time – would never return to Germany.**

**Only weeks later, the Nazi party came to power.**

*(Pause)*

Excellencies,

**This year marks 80 years since the San Francisco Conference and the founding of the United Nations.**

The Holocaust and the world war – started by Germany – taught us that the **denial of human dignity** destroys lives, nations, cultures.

**The founders of the UN came together in the belief, that the defence of freedom strengthens our shared humanity.**

*(Pause)*

It was the belief in a world order that gave my country the **opportunity to be engaged for peace, prosperity and security** – in the family of nations. In the United Nations.

As Germans, we are deeply grateful for this opportunity.

But it also **means we feel particularly responsible for the [sprich: thee], for our United Nations.**

As Albert Einstein wrote in 1947:

***“No international organisation can be stronger than its component parts want it to be.”***

In other words: it is up to us, the member states.

We are the United Nations.

We want these United Nations to be strong.

*(Pause)*

Today, my country is **running again for a seat as a non-permanent member of the Security Council for the 2027–28 term.**

We do so at a **time of unprecedented instability and upheaval.**

In **Sudan** and neighbouring countries, we are witnessing the **worst humanitarian catastrophe of our time:**

Over 30 million people in need of humanitarian assistance.

Over 12 million forced to flee their homes.

We all need to do more to end this tragedy. The security of the entire region is on the line.

The **terrible war in Gaza** is raging on.

**Hell on earth.** A humanitarian nightmare, as we speak.

**This war must end.**

**The hostages must be released.**

The existence and the security of Israel will always be part of our *raison d'état*.

There **must be** a future in peace and in dignity **for all** in the Middle East.

As we have reaffirmed in this Hall this week: **Two States for two peoples.** The **only** solution.

I commend all those who continue to work tirelessly to find a path to peace, notably the United States of America.

(Pause)

**Iran** has created and armed a network of malign proxy forces destabilizing the region. In addition, it has for many years been engaged in a nuclear program which goes far beyond any plausible civilian use.

For us, it is imperative: Iran **must never** acquire a **nuclear weapon**.

Since Iran clearly **does not comply** with its obligations under the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action agreed to in 2015, we had no choice but to trigger the snapback of sanctions.

Following a clear vote by the Security Council yesterday, sanctions will be effective again later today.

But let me emphasize: we remain open to negotiations on a new agreement.

Diplomacy **can** and **should** continue.

(Pause)

And **on my own continent, in Europe, Russia is waging a war of aggression** against its sovereign neighbour Ukraine.

**A war that Ukraine did nothing to provoke.**

**A war that demonstrates the disregard for the most fundamental of all rules of the UN Charter:**

*that “all Member States shall refrain from the use of force against the territorial integrity of any other state”.*

**A rule that permanent members of the Security Council** bear a particular responsibility to uphold.

*(Pause)*

**And while our minds are focused on current security and humanitarian crises,** we are aware that they are **aggravated by the planetary crises**

**of pollution,**

**climate change**

**and biodiversity loss** – all of which threaten to bring

*more* instability,

*more* conflicts over resources,

*more* lost lives and livelihoods.

(Pause)

At **80 years**, our cherished organization is challenged.

By a budgetary crisis.

By a crisis of multilateralism

and by lack of respect for international law.

At this time of crises, we have set ourselves **three key objectives**.

These have been **at the heart of Germany's work at the United Nations for decades** and summarize our Security Council bid today:

**Justice. Peace. Respect.**

(Pause)

Since joining the United Nations, we have been adamant: **justice means development**.

*“Where ***hunger persists***, there can be no lasting peace,”* German Chancellor **Willy Brandt** said in his **first address to the United Nations in 1973.**

Justice requires that every human being has **access to food. To clean water. To education and to health care.**

Germany is the second largest contributor to the UN-system.

We are one of the **largest donors of humanitarian assistance to Gaza.**

We will continue to **provide aid** through well-established partners operating **in line with humanitarian principles – including the UN.**

This aid **must get through** to the people who **need it most.**

**We repeat our urgent call on Israel to enable safe humanitarian access.**

We support UNHCR's work in refugee camps in Sudan and neighbouring countries.

Through UNHCR, we have **supported** countries in providing shelter, food and medical services for **refugees**.

And we are investing in giving people a **long-term perspective**.

I saw for myself how citizens from Mariupol have been able to find shelter in a Hub created by the UNHCR in the city of Dnipro.

Or how displaced people in Bekka Valley in Lebanon were able to return to their restored communities through the support of the UNHCR.

The concept of justice also means combating climate change.

I myself come from a coastal region in the North of Germany.

I know first-hand the risks and consequences of rising sea levels.

And I can **assure** those **whose safety and livelihoods are already endangered by climate change** today:

**We are, and we remain, by your side.**

**Climate justice means supporting those who are most affected**, helping them adapt and address the losses they are already facing.

It means **significantly reducing emissions globally and keeping the 1.5 degree limit within reach.**

Germany will be a reliable partner in this.

We stand by our target to be climate neutral by 2045.

*(Pause)*

Excellencies,

**Justice. Peace. Respect.**

35 years ago we made a promise:

that a reunited Germany would work towards **peace and stability.**

Our **contributions to peacekeeping and peacebuilding** are proof **that we are keeping that promise.**

German troops, police officers and personnel have **served in 14 peacekeeping missions** over the last three-and-a-half decades.

As we speak, the **German military is contributing** the maritime component to **UNIFIL** off the shores of Lebanon. German military **personnel supports UNMISS and MINURSO.**

And we are contributing financially to the security of Haiti, where gangs are terrorizing the civilian population. A situation where the UN has an essential role to play for peace and security.

We are **proud that highly qualified German nationals are making the UN system work** and evolve in important positions.

Germany will **continue to provide skilled personnel to the UN system**, working for peace, development and human rights at all levels.

*(Pause)*

We are the **largest donor to UN Peacebuilding**.

Germany is **chairing the Peacebuilding Commission** until January of next year. This is in line with our **longstanding commitment to support national peacebuilding** and conflict prevention efforts.

Because we are convinced that resilient civil societies and strong institutions are **essential for addressing the root causes of conflict and for building peace in the long run**. The Women, Security and Peace agenda provides an essential contribution in that regard.

*(Pause)*

Justice. Peace. Respect.

**Respect for the Charter of the United Nations.** Its fundamental goals and principles that we have all pledged to uphold.

It is **here in New York, in the halls of the United Nations**, that **all these Nations come together** to discuss peaceful solutions to conflicts around the world.

**This is where we unite.**

**This is us.**

**There is no other place like the United Nations.**

Excellencies,

It is out of **respect for international law and human rights that Germany**

- works towards the establishment of a **special tribunal for the Crime of Aggression** against Ukraine
- That's why **we support and defend international courts**
- That's why **we work to protect human rights defenders where they are at risk.**

**We stand by international humanitarian law.**

Ladies and gentlemen,

**respect also means reform.**

After 80 years we must **make sure that our institutions represent the world as it is today.**

The **Security Council** needs additional seats – permanent and non-permanent – in order **to reflect the world's actual realities.**

Germany is convinced that additional **permanent seats must go to regions underrepresented today: Africa, Asia and Latin America.**

Now more than ever, we need our **United Nations** to be **fit for purpose.** Therefore, the UN80 process must succeed.

**Today, the United Nations needs our support!**

Excellencies,

We all would only stand to lose in a world  
where might makes right,  
where international rules are obsolete,  
a world where treaties are only binding for the  
weak –  
and where war is the continuation of diplomacy  
by other means.

Such a **world** would ultimately be **governed by force.**

**(Pause)**

**Justice. Peace. Respect.**

That is **Germany's offer** to each and every nation  
represented here in this Great Hall.

It is an offer **to listen, to cooperate, to find solutions.**

**It is an offer, rooted in our willingness to listen carefully** to your concerns.

And it is an offer which we are ready to back up.

It is an **offer you can always count on.**

Now and in the future.

Thank you.